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John Bynner

Life story interview with Paul Thompson

2015

Principle investigator's thematic highlights

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John Bynner

Interviewed by Paul Thomspon

11 June 2015, 29 June 2015

1. Pulled between Intellectual Contexts

My mother had been an artist working in Chelsea, actually, until she met my father, who, being of his day, couldn't imagine a wife working when her husband could support her. He had joined the Prudential Insurance Company at the age of 14 or 15, and spent his whole life in that career, but forced to retire early through an hereditary sight problem that he had, so he lost his sight, and he'd pretty well lost it by the end of the War, even. But otherwise that was his job – he was an insurance clerk – and an administrator of some sort, in a big office. So those were their careers. But he was an avid reader, and collected huge collections of books and first editions and all that kind of stuff – you can see a few of them next door. And very active politically, originally ILP, in the Labour Party, but also mixing this with a great interest in theosophy, Spiritualism, and all that side of life – an odd, not exactly a contradiction, but I grew with both those massive intellectual contexts, if you like, and they had very different reactions on me! One, political and on the Left, and on the other more philosophical, or, more religious almost, which was the theosophy – the Theosophical Society which he was a very active member of. …

[Being active in a Theosophy Society] meant going to meetings and holding meetings at our house – had a big house in Ealing - and it was, and having garden parties and all this kind of things where people would give spiritual - it was linked to Spiritualism. Because it was all-embracing in terms of alternative types of religion, then the Theosophical Society could bring in things like Spiritualists, or mediums. Mediums were strong and they would give people advice at these parties. I grew up with all of that, and I reacted, oddly enough, quite strongly against it.

Is that partly why you became a scientist?

Absolutely. It was almost - I began, increasingly, as I grew up and moved very much towards

science, I suppose, in what I studied, I increasingly became disillusioned with all this, and thought it just didn't stand up … And also, I wasn't very close to my father, … I didn't feel in his own personal life he was actually exemplifying a lot of that! … And with my mother was, who wasn't in any way as committed as he was, but as was the way of the time, she had to give up her own art work entirely when she got married, but she would go along with whatever he was doing, and be part of it, and sign up to it, but had a very nice side, which was much more about people, and being very caring and helpful and that side of life – which he lacked a bit….

I had an older sister who was five years older than me, and she'd almost prepared the ground for me … She became an artist herself, and then taught art, and now lives in Newcastle, where she sets up art exhibitions, and spent a huge campaign saving Tynemouth Station, which is where she lives, saved it from being demolished! So we all have our activism aspect, which we gained from him, ironically. But at the same time, felt that some of it was rather dictatorial and controlling. (pp. 1-3)

2. Schooling

I went to a typical primary school just along the road, which was of its place and time – this was in Ealing. Quite good. And I stayed there until I managed to get a place in Latimer Upper School. So although my father was a dedicated Socialist, he didn't see any contradiction with that – in getting your children into the best school. I even went to a private school initially, when I was evacuated to Slough, because I was seven when the War ended, so I'd had two years in school.

I went to, went to a really rough primary – the ultimate primary school shock/horror, gangs roaming the playground, in Slough – and he, they couldn't stand that, and I was miserable and so bullied that I was sent to a little private school for a while. And I can understand that at the time. When I came to Ealing, back to Ealing after the War, then I was sent to the local primary school, which was brilliant – in Pitshanger Lane. And from there I went to Latimer Upper School.

Well, the [primary school] Headteacher took a shine to me, and took me to concerts in the Albert Hall, so I got an early exposure to that side of life! When I think of it, it was amazing! We would go on a Saturday, and go to the Albert Hall to - not Promenade Concerts, but concerts, and go and have tea in Dickins and Jones, and that sort of thing. She was quite

an influence. and she indicated the kind of school that was the best kind of State primary… But at the secondary school – Latimer Upper – was a Direct Grant Grammar, so it was one of those that's now verged on the edge of the State system. Well, you remember these places. That was considered to be better than the local Grammar School, and I should go there, and so I found that a bit contradictory, as I say you know, my father being a dedicated Socialist! But, of course, Latimer is now a private school. (pp. 5-6)

3. Towards science

[At Latimer Upper] there was a guy called Moody, who actually ended up in Bristol Grammar School, who was quite influential in chemistry. But not, not much, actually. Well, I don't know why. I can't understand why I veered towards physics. I think, intellectually, I found it appealing. But the solidity and certainty of science, which I saw at the time, it's almost as an antidote to theosophy and these endless beliefs that are untested and accepted unquestionably…. So it really was an attraction to scientific method as much as anything else, rather than the specifics of science. Physics and chemistry is what I did at 'A' Level, and mathematics.

And there wasn't a teacher there who really inspired you?

No. (p. 6)

4. Youth Culture

And how would you say you related to the youth culture of the time?

That was a very big part of my life. Because through the friends I had at school, we spread across a wide area of London, and early on I was involved, initially, in cycling clubs, I used to do cycle racing and all this kind of thing, but then I discovered – I'm not sure how – Richmond, and Eel Pie Island, which was the great venue for parties. So from about 16/17 just when I was turning into a real teenager, a young adult, I then became very much part of that scene. The jazz clubs, going up to London to coffee bars, the times of the coffee bar culture,

and then where music was played, and Eel Pie Island, which was a deserted hotel – I don't know if you remember the story of Eel Pie Island? …Parties were announced all over London. It's just like the raves and things that followed! But this was very early. This was in the fifties. … Oddly enough, drugs wasn't significant then, it hadn't really become part of that life. Drinking was. But there was still a fear among young people of, of drugs, even smoking cannabis or something would lead you to heroin everybody believed, and therefore you shouldn't touch it, and I just never did at that time. So yeah, that was almost the Golden Age, I was always meaning to write a book on the growing pains or something, of being 17! Because it seemed to me it's all downhill after that! A great social life, the hedonistic pleasure and terrific social world. … It was also the first exposure to girls in a major way, though I'd been going to dances and things since I was, since the age of 14. (pp. 7- 8)

5. Bristol University: towards psychology

[At Bristol] I did physics and a mixture of other subjects – psychology, economics, philosophy. I don't think there was any chemistry. But physics was the main subject, and after one year I realised it wasn't going to work. I couldn't get motivated in the lab, laboratory context, if you like, in which you had to study, and the mathematics drove me crazy! I couldn't stand that either, because mathematics was taught as an axiomatic subject and had no connection with anything other than itself really, and therefore physicists had to teach the mathematics you needed for physics. But it was the whole atmosphere – the students, the college students and all the rest of it, didn't really interest me.

It was this other side of me pulling more towards the outside, towards the Student Union and various things of that kind. And so psychology, which I began to do, then began to appeal more in terms of the connection between scientific method and people, individuals, and human life and human understanding, and also practical consequences, a whole range of possibilities through psychology. So what I managed to do, because I was on a grant from the Local Authority, to go to the University, they were persuaded to give me an extra year, so I was able to switch to an Honours Degree in Psychology. Which is what I did, and dropped physics…

Social psychology and clinical didn't really get a look-in into those courses. They were very science oriented, in their terms, adapting the principles of the natural sciences to the study of human behaviour. In fact, it was all human behaviour even, it wasn't the human mind

or anything of that sort…_Tolman's particular line in psychology was one that appealed to me particularly, because it introduced the idea of purpose, purpose of behaviour, which was the beginning, you might say, in today's terms, of agencies having a role in action – it wasn't just all automated behaviour, stimulus/response type theory – the sort of Pavlov's dogs and all that kind of thing! You learnt all that, but it was becoming more sophisticated and with a cognitive dimension in the work of people like Tolman. I also got on to these amazing books like Hebb, *The Understanding of Behaviour* – Donald Hebb, a Canadian psychologist who was quite a significant influence on me, and he was very much trying to make the links between neurophysiology and behaviour, so human behaviour, and in a very convincing way. It still stands, that book, as a very significant contribution to this field. But the other element, you're right, was cybernetics and the modelling of behaviour through computers…

So through that, you were becoming interested in statistics as a way of understanding human behaviour?

Well, statistics is just a tool. Yes. So you couldn't do that kind of psychology without doing experiments and the psychological experiments demanded statistical method in order to evaluate their results. So, well, you had to learn statistics, and I took to them quite well. I liked that side of it. (pp. 9-11)

6. The Bristol Student Union: Research making an impact

I became quite active in that. I was the Chairman of the Grants and Welfare Committee. From the moment I arrived, the Union appealed to me. It was that political side of my personality which worked, and also the organisation of events for students, support for students in various ways, so the Committee I ran – the Grants and Welfare Committee – actually handed out money to students who were in difficulty. And that was important.

But the main thing, in terms of research careers, was actually inheriting this survey of student opinion about the University refectory, and suddenly getting interested in what this data from students could tell us about what was right and what was wrong with the facilities, and the whole approach, the whole policy towards student eating. And as I think I say in [that article], the University responded very well to this report, and immediately set in an action plan for doing what I recommended! So I was absolutely amazed! And so doing work, using

things like statistics, collecting data, and then seeing action arising from it, became a very important theme of my career. And one of the things that satisfies me most is the thought you've actually made a contribution, as well as just improving understanding, you improve action. That's stayed with me ever since. (p. 11)

7. Studying Sexuality

I'd got a bee in my bonnet, that you needed to get away from education, engage with the real world – partly for political reasons but also, I suppose, for work – and [in 1961] I saw this job going, "A Study of the Sexual Behaviour of Young People", which was really all to do with the almost panic that was operating then… It was all this massive concern about the rise in venereal disease, as it was called, in young people, and mainly gonorrhoea, and this study was to really try to establish the facts of teenage sexual behaviour, and the Central Council for Health Education established the project, with a guy called Michael Schofield running it. And I got the job. It was a three year research appointment.

I was just one of a team, and our job was to go out and interview young people. We chose three areas of the country: Leeds, Southampton and a bit of London It was a chastening experience, because interviewing young people, at that time, about their sexual behaviour and particularly young women, was incredibly difficult. We didn't make any distinction between young men interviewing young women or any of that sort, it was all just jump in and do it. And the model for doing it was the Kinsey Report, which had had a huge effect prior to this thing getting going, and using their methodology [of] assuming everybody experienced every kind of sexual behaviour imaginable, and you just kept pressing them until they could convince you they hadn't! … Indeed, they were volunteers, and the thing was attacked because of its sampling. Very much so. …

They were properly designed surveys. I can't remember the numbers involved, but my role was a research assistant, whose job was to do that, but I also specialised on the attitude measurement side of it, because I was a psychologist, the other two were sociologists. There were three of us - and we employed more people in these local areas to help us - again, young people of our age, who could interview teenagers. …

I got increasingly disillusioned with certain aspects of the research, and therefore focussed on the attitude side of it, and then based my Ph.D. on that…._So at the same time, I registered at Birkbeck College to do a Ph.D., I think in the first year of that job, because I

wasn't gonna lose that opportunity, even though I didn't want to do it at Bristol, I thought I could do it part-time alongside this job. And that worked pretty well, because I was able to use the data collected from the job for my Ph.D..

And there was this idea of making a special visit to the person who was going to be interviewed, beforehand, is that right? The whole thing was premised on a private interview, and ideally we would hope the young people would come to an office. We established an office in each area where these interviews could take place, but rather than lose the interview we would do it in their homes. So probably more than half of them were done in young people's homes, where we had to persuade their parents that they shouldn't be present, and that was achievable without too much trouble, but very often the presence of the parents was quite obvious! So it was really pretty tough interviewing. But the interviewing was in accordance with an agreed schedule, it wasn't semi-structured or open-ended, it was very much a structured interview that could produce quantitative data. So that's what we were expected to do – work through this interview schedule.

So it was not recorded? Because the book doesn't quote people.

No. There was open-ended information that we analysed and coded and classified, but it wasn't, it wasn't used in that one, no.

Of course, Kinsey used that work to establish what were norms of American behaviour, and then he got attacked by the sampling experts saying, “You can't possibly”, “These figures aren't believable” because the sample was based on volunteers.

Another interesting thing is that, really, of the time, that you decided not to interview people about gay behaviour.

Very little. No, it's odd, because Schofield, himself, had written a famous book on – he was a homosexual himself, and that's what he had focused on, and his original interest was in that – and yet he, it's quite surprising, in a way, that this broader interest really attracted him, which the book on *Sexual Behaviour of Young People* was, at that time, the gay aspect wasn't really part of the agenda. I think you're right, we didn't really address it at all. It was simply based on heterosexual activity in, among the teenage population. And whereas I say, I can't remember the name of his book, he wrote it under a pseudonym actually, and it was quite an important text, because, at the time, of course, it was all illegal. Which was another reason

why, of course, we couldn't engage it within this teenage survey.

And I must ask you, what about Michael Schofield, what was he like as a person?

Well, he wasn't my favourite person, actually. One of the problems I had with the whole study, I think I probably went into it in the article, is that I couldn't believe that the reporting of boys, and the reporting of girls, was so totally diverse, different. I mean, hardly any girl would own up to this kind of sexual activity, whereas boys were only too pleased to brag about it. And that's where one of my major interests, which I've pursued ever since, developed, that it seemed to me you're not going to establish the facts of teenage sexual behaviour through this sort of work, so much as establish what young people feel and think about it, and how they wish to present themselves to others in their own lives, or their identities they have in relation to this area of activity. And Schofield wouldn't accept this at all, so we fell out quite badly over it. (pp. 12-15)

One of the ideas that you developed is influenced by Goffman, is that right? The idea of impression management.

Well, that was the thing that I was referring to earlier, that young people need to leave what they think is a good impression with adjudging what somebody will expect them to be, or what will impress, rather than give a negative reaction to them, and that impression management aspect is very central to this work. I felt this was what was going on in these interviews, frankly. As I say, these young women were denying sexual behaviour to an extent to where, how could it be happening, frankly! The boys were claiming it in a way that, again, how could they possibly be doing it! So it was all then about how you define masculinity, what masculinity means in terms of presenting yourself to some other individual, particularly a young adult. That was really central, I think, to what was going on. And similarly, girls wanted to present one sort of image of being attractive but not sexually loose, or sluts, or all the rest of the stuff that boys describe them as, and boys wanted to be the opposite, all about conquests and sexual achievement in their terms. (p. 17)

8. Young People Smoking and the Government Social Survey.

I got this job, and by the skin of my teeth I then joined the Government Social Survey – as it was called then – which I worked for seven years. So from '63 till 1970 I was there. And the first job, well, I joined somebody who was very influential in my research career, who died in the last year – Aubrey McKennell – who'd done some fantastic work on the effects of aircraft noise, oddly enough, around London Airport, and that [was] hugely influential in getting people compensation for being near aircraft noise, but demonstrating it brilliantly, and combining subjective appraisals and attitudes with physical measurement of actual noise levels and all the rest of it. It was that kind of work.

Anyway, he was running this programme of research on smoking. He'd done a classic text on adult smoking, and it had gone down extremely well with government, and it expanded then towards young people and medical students, and my first job was actually on medical students and smoking.

I learnt everything I needed to know about how to do surveys from McKennell. It wasn't taught in the Psychology Department at Bristol, that was all about experiments, but this was the real works, and at that time the Government Social Survey was the lead, the organisation establishing the standards for this kind of work throughout the country. They were set up during the War, comparable to Mass Observation, that kind of work, and they were part of the Central Office of Information collecting information about the economic behaviour of the population, but also their activities and attitudes in these sorts of areas: doing massive behavioural surveys like the National Passenger Survey and Family Expenditure Survey. That kind of stuff developed out of the work they began during the War. And McKennell was obviously one of their leading people. There were other leading experts there. It was a very good environment in which to start a career in this work area. …

There were no computers! It's hard to imagine how it was done! I mean, it was done through Hollerith you know! … Punch cards. Extraordinary, and yet great reports were produced. There were means of analysing this data. I mean, it was just survey data, just tables were produced. The idea of doing multivariate analysis, you know, real statistical work, wasn't really feasible, even though, theoretically, it existed, but the technology wasn't up to it. And so, yeah, we produced these reports and they went down very well. They were basically describing the population in different areas. (pp. 19-20)

They were very good people there, and leaders in the field who'd written a book, actually, called something like *The Handbook of Survey Research*, based on their experiences of doing this in Wartime. Most of them had worked there since the War, you know, and had been originally employed in the wartime version of the Government Social Survey, and this

laid down the standards for, really, market research, survey research in this country, and it's one of the reasons why we've been one of the leaders in this field, equalling, in many respects, the Americans. In Continental Europe it didn't develop so well and so fast. And the idea of very high professional standards in doing this work, in any area - data collection, ethical issues - all these things were well established through that outfit. So it was a great honour, almost, to work there, in terms of the career I subsequently had. And I've never forgotten what I learnt in the process of every element of the survey – the sampling, the design, the fieldwork, and then the analysis. (p 30)

9. The Young Smoker

Well, *The Young Smoker*, that was a very important piece of work for me. That was a study of children - boys, actually, because girls didn't smoke enough at the time, in a sample of schools, so it was a national representative sample of young people – I think it was 11-15 year olds, I can't quite remember. What I brought to bear on it, with McKennell's help, but very much I think it was my contribution, was to develop a new psychological measures of attitude measurement and semantic differential, to actually study the image that young people had of "the smoker" and "the non-smoker" alongside what they, themselves, would like to be – their ideal self – and how they, what they saw themselves to be – their actual self. So using ideas of identity, but how they perceived the identities of others, like young people who smoked, or young people who didn't smoke. And that proved extremely productive in showing what it was in smoking that would appeal to teenagers, because the amount smoked was hardly anything – it was one cigarette a week defined a smoker, but that was enough. Rather like back in the sexual behaviour thing, to establish in the kid's mind that they were, they smoked, and that could be linked to all sorts of other things in their behaviour, and things like their educational achievements, their social class, all this kind of stuff. You could then link this to the images you found then out of this.

To cut a long story short, came the realisation, or the finding, that what appealed in smoking, to boys, was its association with toughness – the toughness of a soldier, or a sportsman, in a way, though a sportsman was a bit contradictory, not at the time so much. The smoker had that attribute, and the non-smoker didn't. And the boys who thought they smoked aligned themselves more with the smoker image. The other thing that appealed to them was an idea of growing up and being sophisticated, and, therefore, a party-goer and all the rest of

it – identifying with that made it very difficult to give up smoking once you'd started, or say you weren't a smoker. So all this became part of how you related to other people, and how you were seen. And ironically, this toughness appealed across the board in school, it was the outside social life, the youth culture operating outside the school, these were the values which could be really in conflict with the kind of school values where young people had to play the game of actually being what the schools expectedif they. Part of that, of course, particularly with the pressure of parents, was educational achievement - to succeed on that front. So you had this different balancing act of having to operate in these different worlds, and sustain your identity in all of them, and smoking was attractive both to the achievers and the non-achievers, to a degree, because it actually gave you an attribute that most young boys value.

But the other side of all this – just to complete the story – was that this was very useful information in approaching young people, and framing the appeals to them to not smoke, or to give up smoking…. The whole health campaign, which this was meant to feed, smoking and health would then be informed by and guided by knowledge of this identity work that was going on on the groups you wanted to influence – youth culture outside the school, and youth culture inside the school. …

So this was, I guess, the most important thing you'd published by this point in your career?

Oh, absolutely, yes. (pp. 19-21)

10. The Plowden Follow-up

We've got to the sixties, mid-sixties. I think for your other main project [then] was this follow-up, for the Plowden Committee's 1963 Report on English Primary School Education.

Yes. Well, it was exactly that. The National Foundation for Educational Research, I'd been heavily involved in the previous Plowden Survey, which was just a survey of seven year olds … It was a survey of adults, of children, but also their parents, as I recall. And the idea was really to find out what people felt about their progress and their aspirations. And then, of course, with the longitudinal data, one could see the extent to which these pathways were being laid down earlier. So partly because of my experience of the medical students, and thinking that should have been a longitudinal survey, I was very attracted to this idea of a

follow-up of a group, over time, that you could then start seeing how their lives were changing, and not only their lives, but their attitudes – the whole thing… (pp 29-30)

11. The Time Dimension in Research

It was at this point, from [the Plowden follow-up] you realised the importance of time?

Absolutely. And the beginnings of a life course perspective that, really, people's lives are shaped by these experiences happening through the normal developmental process of just the environments in which people grow in, but also the influence of policy on that – policy frameworks, external events - and in other words, a historical dimension to the understanding of human development, which is bringing that secular change into the picture as well. And the more I got into this, the more I realised the limitation, say, of psychology, that had no interest, whatsoever, in social change! …

You have a nice phrase that you came to realise from the study, "the great power of the time dimension in social scientific enquiry". I like that phrase!

Well, it's time in a variety of ways. It's historical time, developmental time – yes, absolutely! And the time at which you do things, the time at which you collect data, the period effect. I've written a number of things about this. Time is really vital and quite complex, because it has these three effects on data at any point in time - the period, the cohort and the development. (p. 31-2)

Of course, the time dimension is the other thing that structural equation modelling allows you to deal with, you see. It's made for longitudinal data, it's made for life course study. Life course study is, by definition, longitudinal because one of the four components of the life course is developmental change in individuals, and that's where structural equation modelling really originally paid off.

The other aspects, of course, are historical, the historical shifts over time, and linked lives was the other vital thing to me about the life course. It's to take into account social relationships, that you're a cohort that is moving in a convoy, a cohort like the Roman army, it's linked together, and it's basically as a family, but it extends to the community or people at

work and all the rest of it…. But that's the most difficult element of all to deal with in modelling, and that's where the qualitative approach comes in. (pp. 46-7)

12. At the Open University, 1970

Well, in the early years, when this was all being pioneered, it was an incredibly stimulating place to work, and it was the complete opposite of the Government Department that was the Government Social Survey, because everybody was talking, debating, arguing, all the time. So I, my job in the course was, obviously I did all the bits and pieces – the radio programme, the television and all that – but mainly, as you know, the job of the OU was to write these course units, it's a writing job, and the whole outfit was like a super publishing ... publisher, really, with some of the functions of a university….

And all those elements of educational technology, radio, television, because the producers were members of the team as well, when it worked well, it worked brilliantly. But it had its problems and some people couldn't manage the job, didn't deliver the work, and that was a major problem. But I moved on to… "Research Methods in Education and Social Sciences", where I set up projects for students to do in teams, going to local schools and collect data, mini surveys all over the place. I couldn't see why not, but some of this stuff was very radical in OU terms, stretching the limits of what they thought was feasible in a distance teaching exercise – it was devolving activity, and project work of a kind an ordinary university would get students to do, into people's homes, and negotiating with local facilities where the work could be carried out. And, anyway, it worked. (pp. 32-33)

13. At the Institute of Social Research, University of Michigan

That was another highly formative experience… A year in the Institute of Social Research, Michigan, where I really learnt how computing, how the use of statistics, everything was really done. That was an academic survey institution, although it had parallels to the Government Social Survey, it was a major department of the University of Michigan, where lots of the people had joint appointments into the different Departments of Psychology, Sociology, Bio-Statistics, whatever it was. So many of them were teaching as well as researching, doing their research in ISR but actually doing their teaching work elsewhere.

That mix was, it was so effortless, and so American, how easy they find to, found to organise this, whereas it was almost unimaginable here! And libraries open all night and all that sort of stuff. You had to do computing overnight there because everything was done on main-frames, there were obviously no desk-top computers, so you had to actually get your programme right, the specification, the analysis, the one you wanted to do, and then get it running overnight, and some people would have waited all night for their results to come through, and then you would input another programme spec for another piece of analysis. And you had to pay for every second of computer time. So if I hadn't had a bit of Fulbright money spare, that would have been a problem for me. But it was very much a discipline, because it forced you to think through what you were doing before you actually went so far as to get a computer to do some work for you! The complete opposite of now! And I met wonderful people there!

I was in a team of people working on a thing called, "Youth in Transition". A guy called Jerry Buckman led that, and again, that team I worked with, we analysed Youth in Transition data. That was my first significant scientific article… I think it was one of the most important things, the first genuine high-powered research article I'd got involved in, that was published in an American journal – *The Journal of Research and Adolescence*.

The argument was that rather than delinquency being a negative response to adversity was a means of compensating. It was because, again, of this toughness attribute, delinquents could carry, in the school setting, could carry a certain kind of status, which was a substitute for academic failings, and they were able to restore their self-esteem through being delinquent, which was the opposite of what the psycho-pathological view of delinquency was, ... that delinquency should have a lowering effect on self-esteem… So I wrote that article with [Jerald] Backman and another colleague, [Patrick] O'Malley, and as I say, it was my first experience, not only of writing an article of that kind, but of achieving the standards for it that American journals demand. (pp. 34-36)

14. Archiving and research access: conflicting viewpoints

Well, it's been a battle, and it's a matter – I think a very interesting one – of two different cultures about this, and the social science take on it, with funding largely coming from the Economic and Social Research Council, or government, latterly – not initially, but latterly – [the idea] has been that publicly funded data collected for research purposes should be

available to the community, which, in this case, is academics who could make effective use of it. Also it's the closest we get to the natural sciences in terms of replication, the chance for other people to re-analyse people's data. Well, you've set up an archive for this purpose – not necessarily to challenge what others are doing, but get something else out of it, other perspectives. So that tradition of research data as not only serving the purpose of a particular project, but as a resource for others to use, was strong in the social sciences. Whereas in the medical sciences, which also are very closely involved in longitudinal studies, and had been the foundation of the early ones, the perinatal mortality surveys, which the big cohort studies were based on, they were all about conditions of birth, and early infant mortality and illness. Their tradition would have been quite different, because clinical research is based on the notion of a medical scientist working in a clinical situation with individuals who are going to participate in some kind of clinical trial or experiment, and in this case a longitudinal survey, the '46 Cohort, and therefore the data is private to the individuals who collected it, and only they are in a position both to understand it and collect it, and no tradition of archiving, nothing - a privileged collaboration with outsiders, but no release of data as such. And that's been a major tension for years. It's not fully resolved even now, though there's been a move more and more in the social science direction….

But there's also the issue of confidentiality, isn't there, which is related to access.

Well, that's a very interesting question, almost for other kinds of reasons. No data should or could ever be released in any way that the individuals in it could be identified - that was the traditional view, so it's all anonymised data. (pp. 38-39)

15. Migration and Longitudinal Studies

There's another point about the sample, which, again, you touch on. It's about migration, in and out migration, and how you deal with that in these long-term studies.

It's a massive problem, and it's almost insoluble. Because the essence of a longitudinal study is a follow-up of individuals over time, and that, by definition, means a population as it was historically some time ago, and whatever sample you take of that population, you are then pretty well stuck with, in terms of the longitudinal credibility of it. Now, if you add members

to it, who weren't there at the time, or were born overseas, for example, but happen to be the same age as the existing cohort members, those people are not part of the original longitudinal enquiry. That's how people were traced in the National Child Development Study, through school records. They simply got every child who was the right age, and then by definition, they were part of the follow-up survey…

So either you, you build that into the design, and therefore you've got a compromise – which is what the Panel studies do – between having a sample that was there from birth, in effect, and a sample that then you've created as new immigrants move in, and so it's augmented/supplemented by immigrants, so it can reflect the population as it is now. Or if you stick with the original one, then that sample that's in the cohort that you're following up, is actually continually getting out of date. And that's quite a dilemma in terms of the population as it is now. So these studies, by definition, in a purely longitudinal sense, are historical, they're not about the population now. (pp. 42-43)

16. Technological development, Analysis and Theory

We talk about big data now, and the sky is the limit, and the microchip, and then finally the facility of having stuff on your desk that, at one time, you had to go to the University of London to analyse at the University of London's central computer, is unbelievable! When we first heard about desktop computing, I can remember people couldn't believe in it! But you, on a memory stick, that big, you can cap 30 gigabytes of storage, and that means you can have the whole of the British Household Study just there in front of you, you know! So this is a massive change. It's a massive change in terms of what you can do, statistically, in terms of analysis, but also what you can do in terms of storage and secondary analysis. This whole resource becomes feasible in a massive way. ..

There are three things that have happened. One was the technological transformation of this field through the access to manipulation and storage of data. The second is that that released analytic potential on a scale that was unbelievable, because the mathematics became reality in terms of actual procedures and processes that could be used with ease, of which structural equation modelling is one of the classic examples. And the third was theory. Theory, itself, could take off, because it could become holistic, interdisciplinary, anything you like, because you could encompass such a wider range of evidence and information.

It's a wider range because you can test more widely?

Well, you can test, yes, you can utilise data on a very wide scale both across time, particularly the time dimension becomes incredibly important. When I first got involved in the 1970 cohort, the person who was running it, Neville Butler … didn't believe that you could do longitudinal analysis, because he couldn't see how you could link the data. It was just too big, too vast. And when I evaluated the NCDS for secondary analysis, people told me, "I've had this data set for a couple of years, it's daunting to even try to look at it". All that becomes swept away, so the possibilities of life course analysis, and multi-dimensional, multi-faculty, multi-facility coverage of human lives, becomes all accessible in a way that it didn't in the past, and that means theory can develop accordingly too. You don't need to compartmentalise stuff to actually analyse it together. That's basically it. (pp. 43-44)

17. Structural Equation Modelling

There was a leading statistician called Jöreskog, Swedish, from Uppsala in Sweden, who developed a means of really testing theory directly through a modelling method. Basically it's multiple regression written over and over and over again, and again, it was undo-able until computing had the facility to do the statistical estimation side of it, or even manage it at any level really. It's called "structural equation modelling", it's representing a theory in terms of a set of causal relationships. So it's evaluating a causal system really. And that's what it is. Now, he joined forces with a computer expert, and IT expert, called Dag Sörbom, and between the two of them, bouncing off ideas between each other, the IT side of it and the statistical mathematical side of it, could dynamically interrelate to a point where they could come together. And the whole of this system of, basically, equations, mathematical equations, could be tested simultaneously, in an instant, through modern computing methods. And that's where structural equation modelling depended utterly on technological advance – this time on the analysis side – and that's apart from the all other great merits technology has brought in storage and all the rest of it. This is purely for the manipulation of data at high speed, and vast quantities, and huge numbers of variables – whatever you like, the sky's the limit. No limitations really. And structural equation modelling is, is all about that.

And when does that actually appear, then?

I think their original book was '79, wasn't it? …Now, even then, computing hadn't got to the desktop stage, this was all done by mainframe computers, but mainframe computers were now handling statistical packages that could begin to move in this direction. So all the well-known techniques of multiple regression, analysis of variance, and all this sort of thing was being developed and could be used, because of technological facility which was now available and hadn't been in the past, on a large scale. It was all done by hand before. Things like factor analysis people worked out on pieces of paper. (pp. 44-7)

18. Intergenerational Studies

I mention it because_in statistical terms, whenever you add another dimension, like children, to a study, you almost run out of degrees of freedom. You need fairly large samples to do the kind of statistical work you want to do. But the '58 Cohort did study children on one occasion. We got money from the States to link up with a study in the US, a national longitudinal study of young people, NLSY – National Longitudinal Study of Youth – where they, since 1986, on a sample which overlaps with the 1958 sample in terms of age and birth date, since '86 they go back to the children of the cohort, so that's the very best example of an inter-generational study where you've got information on the grandparents, the parents who then become the cohort members, and the cohort member's children. So you can get data on up to three to four generations, actually. It's incredible. But we've only done it once because the money was available only for one go at this, in the '58 Cohort, so we've got one cross-section with these children available, and that means just like a cross-sectional inter-generational study is possible....

The thing is, there are very few studies that have followed up children from birth to a point where they're able to have children themselves. To get the full range, you've got to wait until they're about 30 or 35 before they stop having children, and that's the full sample of children, inter-generationally, is when you no longer are getting any more of them, otherwise it's always slightly distorted, slightly biased. But so it's a hell of a long time to wait, and that's why people haven't done it. I think it's a shame, but I feel it's where the world is going. (p. 48)

The other development [we have followed more recently is] inter-generational

[studies] – following up the children of these cohort studies - which is what we also began to do. And that was one of the tasks in City, initially, and then in IoE second, we did a follow-up of the children of the cohort in the early thirties, all children of all the cohort members who were born, of course, themselves, at a particular date. And then we did a similar thing in the '58 cohort ... in the '70 cohort, when we were at City University, so we did children in the '58 cohort at City, and children in the '70 cohort, when we were in the Institute of Education. (pp. 83-4)

19. Co-ordinating the 16-19 year old ESRC Initiative

Towards the end of your time at the OU, you started working on the ESRC initiative on 16-19 year olds. This is one of your main, big fieldwork research experiences, isn't it?

You couldn't be more right. … It was new, in a number of ways. First of all, it was the next stage – social and economic change was the thing that preceded it… The 16-19 initiative didn't have quite the same budget, but its focus on young people was very much around the issues of economic and political socialisation. …

The whole issue there was the effect of social change as reflected in labour market growth or collapse at the time of the massive industrial transformation of this country at the end of seventies/the beginning of the eighties, and the consequences through the eighties for the lives of young people – transition to adulthood. So there were four areas. Area study came into the frame for the first time…

The two extremes were Liverpool, with the collapsing maritime industry, and Swindon, an expanding new tech town – old railway city that was now booming on the golden crescent of new technology, going from Cambridge to Bristol. And the other two towns were Sheffield, which was a very high-skilled area that had suffered major collapse through competition from the Far East, and then another was Kirkcaldy in Scotland, which, in many ways, was a microcosm of Scotland, in terms of its economy, local economy – old industries collapsing, new industries coming along – and so that was the fourth area….

It also led to a very valuable extension, which is almost the last component of the development of this whole area that I'm interested, which was comparative. We did this Anglo-German comparative project which produced two books, and tons of articles, and very very stimulating in terms of trying to get to grips with the meanings of the cultural

assumptions and understandings in Germany, about this youth transition issue, and the one prevailing here.

I had to co-ordinate four research teams, each very powerful, autonomous outfits, and bring them together into communal agreements about how to do this work, and what we should do in the design of it, developing it, data collection – all these aspects…. As people have said, organising academics is like herding cats, they're all doing their own thing, and they all had their own loyalties, and their careers were, of course, based in their universities, not in the 16-19 initiative. But it was stimulating all over the place.

It also had the other dimension – I shouldn't underwrite this – where, for the first time, I think, we really developed a qualitative component. So there was quite a few articles, and certainly a very strong book or two on this much more biographical approach, and ethnographic approach, to young people….Inge Bates, and a guy called George Riseborough, for example, they did these life histories, or biographical accounts, I suppose, of young people in different relationships to the labour market and particularly those on youth training schemes. It was all how they talked, how they thought, and I think some of that was very influential. And we brought it into, but not very heavily, into our book, *Careers and Identities*. Well, that was the culmination of all of it.

We had a nice mix of people. It was a very multi-disciplinary team… I was already beginning to move away from psychology then, moving much more towards this more interdisciplinary holistic approach to getting an understanding of this stuff. But it, it worked well, and the team, though it was a difficult one to manage at times, overall I think people were pretty happy with it. (pp. 51-56)

20. Men and Women in Transition

Because [women] in terms of the life course that they were happy to pursue, more so than men, which was a much more mixed life course of family and work generally, than men, which tend to be dominantly about occupation, work, labour market, that they were able to fit into a flexible labour market in terms of part-time work and all the rest of it, more easily. And also, of course, it was moving more and more over to white-collar work. The people who missed out in the late seventies/early eighties were those who traditionally, from an unskilled, unqualified base, had gone into manufacturing industry, and those jobs were disappearing at a rate of knots. Now, women who had tended to move more into the office work type of job as

what they favoured, and the factories were never really [what] they would put their first hopes on, that worked better for them, that change. So if you look at employment statistics and all the rest of it, you see them far less damaging, in female terms than male terms, through that huge transformation of the British labour market. (p. 57)

21. The first birth cohort studies

Britain had this grand tradition of developing birth cohort studies almost by accident, and they became, rightly, a world leader in this field, in the sense that the whole thing was prompted, initially, by a decision to have a perinatal mortality survey in 1946, just in advance of the National Health Service being established. So the 1946 Study began as that sort of survey, and then it was recognised by James Douglas, who ran it, that it would be great, or very valuable, to follow up these babies.

Not on the scale of the whole sample, which was about about 15/16,000 babies born in a single week in 1946 (excluding Northern Ireland), but he reduced that sample to a sample of roughly 5,000, and weighted towards the more successful children, or those in grammar schools, because there would have been too few of them otherwise, and feeling that there were too many in large families, and single parents. All that whole structure of families and demographic society was so different then. Now, it would be almost the opposite, you'd actually weight in favour of the disadvantaged, because they're seen as of most policy interest. But nearly all these birth cohort, or longitudinal studies, had been focused in that direction – the study of talent, what was it that enabled children to succeed, rather than what made them fail?

Anyway, the '46 then, after that, became almost a movement in 12 years later, to establish another such study, again, basically a perinatal mortality survey, in 1958 – 12 years later – to see, then, how the effects of the National Health Service were mapping out. So it was very health-oriented. It was about, as I say, mortality of babies, fundamentally.

[The second cohort] wasn't the National Child Development Study at all initially, it was called The British Birth Survey, or something of that sort, because purely by, almost by chance, the government set up the Plowden Committee, which was looking in that period, which would have been '65 – that was when Plowden was sitting and drawing his conclusions – it needed a survey of seven year olds, and it was pointed out that this '58 cohort could generate such a sample. The babies would be exactly the right age, if they were traced, and

you can trace babies when they enter schooling by their age - so the idea, then, was to put together a sample, to trace the original perinatal mortality survey children via that route, plus, of course, including, as they did, the others who'd actually immigrated into the country in the intervening years. So as with the British Household Panel Study, or any such study of this kind, it's continually becoming out of date, in one sense, in terms of the population that exists when you start it.

Anyway, that's what happened. So you had a sample created at age seven, of the '58 birth cohort, and about 17,000 babies had actually been surveyed… Then after that, it was decided to follow the sample regularly. In the meantime, James Douglas had been successful in persuading the powers that be – funders of various sort – to actually support follow-up of the '46 cohort. So we'd already got two moving along, totally independent of each other, it's true to say.

James Douglas became very famous, ironically not for his medical work – he was a trained physician and a medical researcher – but for two very famous books, *The Home and the School*, and *All Our Futures*, which reported these studies as the children got older. And the subsequent sweeps - because the sample was relatively small by the standards of the studies that followed them, quite regular follow-ups occurred…

But the problem, then, was data management and analysis of needing high powered methods that didn't exist, so very simplistic things were done. In the '58 cohort, because of the size of it, the follow-ups were much less frequent, so the next one after seven – so there was a birth survey, which then could be linked ultimately, not initially, but ultimately to the '58 follow-up Plowden Survey, and then the next one was 11, and then the one after that 16, and then the one after that 23 – so there were only about four over the first 20 years. …

Now, Neville Butler founded it with these people, medical specialists in birth and natality, but the person who really picked it up and ran with it then – the '58 cohort – was somebody called Kellmer Pringle, Mia Kellmer Pringle, who became very well-known as the person responsible for the study. Because it then became known as the National Child Development Study – it wasn't given that name until then, because it wasn't managed as longitudinal or conceived as longitudinal. She established the National Children's Bureau almost for the purpose of running this study. It was seen as so important and big in those terms that you needed almost a whole organisation to run it, and that's what she did. The NCB went much wider than that as it developed, but that was the core of its origins. And just to complete the story, it's worth mentioning that 12 years later, having set this thing up to see how the National Health Service was getting on, then the call came for another one, or a

movement grew for another one 12 years later, so one would have a charting of child development in response to the Welfare State and the actual Health Service – going much wider than perinatal mortality, clearly, much wider into early childhood and all the rest of it, but still very focused on child health in relation to these first surveys, surveys of birth.

It was Butler then, Neville Butler, who put all his efforts in this next one. I remember, actually, going to a meeting where he, he addressed in his enthusiastic style, the possibilities that this was going to open up. In this case, it was decided, from the very beginning, the 1970 birth cohort study, called "The Child Health and Education Survey", that it would be longitudinal throughout. It was conceived as a longitudinal survey from the very collection of the birth data onwards. But each of these birth surveys generated very substantial medical texts written by the medical, gynaecological, whatever they were - obstetricians, obstetrician type people who were involved in designing the birth survey. So it was a very clear medical origin. Anyway, the '70 cohort then got going and had a rather chequered history. It did begin very effectively by producing early studies of special groups within the sample at 22 months and 42 months, but they were rather oddly chosen samples with distinctive characteristics of the birth situation, and the medical aspects to this. But nevertheless, they formed a kind of sample. So 22 months and 42 months. And then the next major survey was at five. Then the one after that at 10.

Then Neville Butler retired – he ran it throughout. Kellmer Pringle had taken over the other one until she died in the early eighties, and Butler then got this [new] survey going. Then, ironically, when it came to the age 16 survey, he'd retired and he took the survey with him, he didn't want it to stay in the Institute of Child Health in Bristol. And then there was a battle royal about who owned it, and all sorts of issues that have not come to haunt these studies, but have come to produce a need for what amounts to institutionalisation, standardisation, agreements, ethical issues, because of this whole battle. It went into court and all the rest of it, as to who owned the Study and what the Study was, and basically the Study comes down to a database of names and addresses, so who owns that, really? …

Neville Butler … himself, didn't believe you could link data longitudinally. I mean, the primitive nature of what people had to hand in analysing data in this country is unbelievable, and a longitudinal data set was seen as beyond - almost unimaginable. Yet, despite that, … the idea of a large, large-scale surveys involving follow-up of individuals from birth onwards, was seen as hugely productive potentially, in terms of both medical insights, or the origins of various kinds of health condition, but then more broadly, particularly with James Douglas' work on *The Home and the School*, in understanding the

processes of what we'd now call “life course” - development and the origins of life chances. So they recognised all this 20, 30 years in advance of the technology that would enable them to do it. That's why I considered Butler a visionary, in the sense he was critical to the establishment of the '58 cohort, but then very much the paediatrician really. And then, of course, he founded the '70 cohort, where he actually conceived that as a longitudinal survey, even though it, as I say, it was almost unimaginable what he'd do with the data once he'd got it…

Kellmer Pringle, James Douglas and Neville Butler … went around like missionaries, with that sort of zeal, to convert government particularly, and ultimately Research Councils who had no interest in, to the cause of this kind of investigation. And there was always resistance because clinical medicine didn't see this as valuable data at all, it was not experimental, it was observational, in their terms, and therefore of pretty low importance compared with the work they did on controlled trials and all the rest of it! … They had no concept of history, or the context of lives, as having any significance for medicine at all. And so that was the argument against wasting money on these projects. So it's even protected from the cuts (LAUGHS) which is amazing! (LAUGHS) So does that answer your But, in fact, the arguments of Douglas, Kellmer Pringle and others prevailed in certainly getting modest amounts of money, but it was all on short-term research grants, there was no continuity of the kind now that is built in to the infrastructure for this whole enterprise, which is huge, and is now seen as a massive government investment that we would be crazy to lose.. (pp. 59-63)

22. Problems in Archiving and Re-using Longitudinal Studies

The '58 cohort study survived up until age 23 in the National Children's Bureau, and at that point it was funded entirely by government, the survey of age 23 was supported by government. The ESRC I don't think even had any kind of stake in it, and they were very disappointed in what came out of it - the government funders – they felt the kind of reports they were seeing weren't of interest or valuable to policy. So it was decided that rather than waste this data, it should be deposited in the Data Archive in Essex. So that was the first recognition of something which had started as a medical study, should be made publicly accessible, because if the government wasn't going to get much out of it, maybe social, and behavioural, and medical scientists would be able to, if it was accessible to them through that route. So it was a major breakthrough for the survey, in helping towards its survival, but also

to the Archive. Now, the trouble with that was … that nobody was using it! Because having deposited it, people made enquiries but they never seemed to get anywhere with it….

I was asked then, because of my background in survey research, and I'd had one or two dealings, I suppose, with the ESRC, to do a scoping study of how we might improve the use of the '58 cohort, and make it a real resource for scientists that they could, and would, use…

I discovered, in fact, that the reason people weren't using the data was, first, they didn't know about it. Second, that they had found it extraordinarily difficult to use, and many had got the data set but never managed to analyse it – they couldn't handle that sort of complexity, and they didn't have the training or the understanding or, or how to apply the appropriate statistical methods to analyse it And the other thing that was wrong with it was that the location of the study in the Data Archive and the National Children's Bureau simply didn't fit. … And anyway, then my report suggested that the solution to this was to move the study away from a body like the National Children's Bureau, and locate it in a university where there was a research unit that could handle it. And the one that appeared was just down the road from NCB – a thing John Fox ran, called the Social Statistics Research Unit at City University. The ESRC came up with that solution… and Fox then was able to expand his little outfit to incorporate the '58 cohort study. (pp. 64-66)

23. The User Support Unit for Longitudinal Studies Nationally: at City University

But the other thing I also discovered in my travels, because I did a survey, and I interviewed a hell of a lot of people about this, was that for these large and complex data sets, you needed an interface between the research user and the data. This was partly through excellent documentation, so everything was clear - what the codes meant, and all this kind of stuff, of a kind, a level that they'd never imagined before, because researchers, or those who wrote the original reports, just didn't see the need for any of that documentation. And also, to be on the end of a phone line, where if somebody ran into trouble they could get immediate help and assistance with getting stuck in interpreting some variable or whatever it was. So that [was the] idea of the User Support Unit – which I picked up, actually, from the University of Surrey. They'd had similar problems with the General Household Survey. Angela Dale, in fact, set up a kind of unit that gave that kind of help. And that was the other thing that then ESRC decided to fund at City University, so the study would be relocated there, with the back

up of a User Support Unit that would not only help the existing users of the project from data collected up until the age of 23, but they would then follow through the work done on the scoping study to make a proposal to ESRC for another complete survey. And that was their job.

Then John Fox, at some point, having accepted the '58 cohort and all the rest of it, for whatever reason decided he'd move on, and he moved back to where he'd come from – government – and became the Chief Medical Research Officer…

ESRC had, in the meantime, placed somebody called Alan Marsh in the City University Social Statistics Research Unit - to work on developing the proposal for this next round of data collection, which was increasingly coming to look like 1991, when the cohort would be aged 33. ... And just to complete the story, Alan Marsh's brief was mainly not only to help develop the proposal, but to actually raise the substantial money from government departments to fund half of it, so ESRC would fund half, and these government departments fund the other. So he spent all his time persuading government departments that if they had a role in designing, very directly, the survey, alongside the academics funded by ESRC, then they would get a much better deal than they'd had previously from the Age 23 Survey.

Anyway, because Fox had gone, the job became advertised, and I think I may have been asked to apply, I don't know, but I did, and then [in 1988] I found myself appointed [to City] … So that's how I got the job! (pp. 66-7)

24. Bringing the Cohorts to City University

So there you are [in 1989], you've got the '58 Study, you're in charge of that, then how did you come to take over the 1970 one?

Well, in the meantime, because of my interest in these things, and interest in youth, which was my subject really, I'd actually got involved, or appointed, been appointed by ESRC as the co-ordinator of what was called "The 16-19 Initiative… I carried that with me in to City University, so I had that continuing job.

But in the meantime, because of my involvement in that, Neville Butler was always looking for people who could help the '70 Cohort Study, and he tended to go for a very unusual group of people as trustees, who were the grand and the good, they were ex-Ministers, and well, just a string of dignitaries really, rather than academics, and he wanted

one or two academics as well on this Board of Trustees. So he asked me to join the Board of Trustees of what was the International Centre for Child Studies, which is what he had set up when the cohort had reached age of 16, to run the Age 16 Survey. And he actually got money from that and was - because he went adrift, in a way, he thought he could be so convincing to all these people with money or interest, that this would transform the lives of children, that if if they put money into it, this, that would be this huge return they'd got. So he believed, by leaving Bristol University, he could fund it. Well, that didn't turn out to be true! And, in fact, the person who baled it out – The 16-Year-Old Survey, which took about 18 months to complete, and had horrendous problems – had Robert Maxwell as actually the funder of it, or quite a substantial amount. And this Trust was raising the money. He did manage to raise quite a bit of money, but not on the scale that was needed for the fieldwork of a survey of this kind.

What sort of horrendous problems are you talking about, then?

Oh, in the '70 Cohort, there was a teachers strike. He had a very very ambitious data collection plan, almost unbelievable! There were about 18 research instruments these kids had to go through. It was based on his experience as a clinician, that you could really take over a person's life for a day or two to collect this data (LAUGHS), doing that on a scale of 17,000 babies, you know! Five year olds! And then 16 year olds! And so there'd been quite a bit of drop-out on that front, but the other side of it was, and also these kids, particularly when they were teenagers, they didn't like being medically examined and all that! But the worst thing of all, then, a lot of the data was collected from teachers, headteachers, health visitors collected the data in the field – he recruited them at a very low price, he didn't use professional survey people. And then the teachers strike just completely wrecked it. they refused to administer these instruments… The long and short of it was that some of these instruments only got completed by about six or eight thousand people out of a potential seventeen thousand…

Well, because of my connections with Neville – now, Neville was getting on in years, I mean, he'd obviously retired a considerable time before this period when I went to City – and at one time then he suddenly, in effect, turned up one day with the Honorary Secretary or Treasurer of ICCS to ask if I'd be interested in taking over the study. Now, I knew its record from somebody called Joan Payne, who'd actually done a review of the '70 Cohort, and had pretty well given it the thumbs down, and said it was unsaleable because of the 16 year olds.

And she'd been employed by Neville to promote it! It was all grand ideas, but piecemeal, and very inefficient organisation, I'm afraid, even though he had the vast teams of people, when the data came in, working on it, doing things to it. But it just didn't have the professionalism that ultimately is needed, and now is almost taken for granted in this whole area. Anyway, he decided it couldn't go on, and the organisation was pretty well collapsing, and hardly anybody was going to be left employed, this great army that he'd got coding and working on the stuff had to go. And I was asked if I would inherit the Study and two of the people who were working on it – Research Officers – the others left.

I jumped at it, because, against some opposition I must say, from colleagues if nobody else, in the sense that the '58 Cohort was a gigantic enterprise and didn't need anything else. Anything else was a diversion, and certainly something with a record like this. But I could see the potential of it in, for the first time, in offering cohort comparison in a systematic way.

The '46 Cohort you couldn't compare with directly because it wasn't accessible. The rules that were imposed on that by Douglas, originally, and then Mike Wadsworth who ran it when Douglas died was more one of clinical research, where the data is very much in the ownership of the people who collected it, and they have this implicit contract, or explicit contract with the cohort members that nobody else will get near it or touch it, and that was maintained, and has been for the '46 Cohort, throughout its life….It's loosened, but you have to go through permissions procedures, and the model was one of collaboration. "We don't mind collaborating with people if they do it with us, but we're not gonna hand the data to anybody". I still think they don't. It isn't deposited, that data set, even now…

I agreed to take [the 1970 cohort] it on because I could see that the potential analytic and historical value of it would multiply with time. We could get over this Age 16 Survey by using methods of imputation, we could fill the gaps in the data, but even whatever there was better than nothing - and put all our efforts in getting the next survey done. … (pp. 67-70)

We've now [also] got the Longitudinal Study of Young People, though they're now in their late twenties/thirties or something, in the set-up as well. It's an age cohort study, not a birth cohort study, because it begins in the teens… (p. 75)

Now with, of course, the merger with UCL, we're linked to the Ageing Studies, the '46 cohort, that's in their sixties! … It's been in UCL for a very long time. It was in Michael Marmot's Department for some time, Community Epidemiology, and now is in a separate, very important Centre in UCL, linked internationally to American studies and across the world, called "HALCYON", run by Diana Kuh. But under Mike Wadsworth it was in the Epidemiology Department at UCL. (p 76)

25. The battle for the cohorts: Essex, and the move from City to the Institute of Education

At one time, of course, Essex was due to take over these cohort studies, I don't know whether you knew that? Oh yes! That was decided in a national strategy developed by ESRC, that the future of these longitudinal studies lay in one place. We, at one time, were kind of in partnership, then we were bidding against each other for who would run the UK Centre for Longitudinal Studies. Now, the ESRC had always been very keen to get the best return it could from the Essex thing, which was a real gold-plated enterprise. I mean, that building was built for it, you know. Well, the University was very good, they poured money into it….So that was the jewel in the crown for ESRC, and they thought it made sense to co-ordinate all this, they had various consultants and people who recommended it.

But in the meantime we managed to fight that off – the takeover – partly because of the nature of the studies that we were doing were so different from the Panel Study in certain respects. But what we learnt from the Panel Study was if money was available to invest in really good documentation, the user support aspect, all these things could make these into genuine research resources – and that's what the Panel Study had been set up to be from the very beginning. It was seen as a means for others to do research, it wasn't a tiny little research team. The tradition of the cohort studies [was] a little team doing basically research around data they were collecting. Then, in our case it had finally been deposited in the Archive so others could use it, but up until then, of course, it was just the National Children's Bureau team that had analysed the data. So we spent a huge amount of time documenting, going in for new means of storing the data.

A lot of this was due to transformations of computer technology and new methods. This is still way before the period of Windows and desktop computing, this was still main-frame computing, but increasingly it was moving in that direction. At City University we did have a one gigabyte computer which was seen as fantastic, and then bought another gigabyte where the sky was the limit! It's hard to imagine all that, but that's where it was, and people had come, grown up - the people running these things - from a period where they'd had virtually nothing…

Anyway, the team got to work on this, and began to build the '70 cohort into a viable usable survey, and for deposit in the Archive, and that was the goal, it should reach the

standards at least of the NCDS. …

I haven't mentioned the move from City to the Institute of Ed… Well, it was all to do with setting up the Joint Centre for Longitudinal Research, and the need, really, to win the battle to preserve the cohorts really, to maintain them as a responsibility – the '58 and the '70 – within the kind of SSRU set-up that existed in City University. And it was decided that City wasn't strong enough to resist the pressures to resist this merger with Essex, and taking the whole thing down there, and that we ought to move somewhere else. So we investigated three places – ironically, UCL was one of them, our first port of call and our choice; the second was LSE; and the third was the Institute of Education – and of the three of them, only the Institute of Education really was keen to have our Unit, and so we went there in 1998.

So ten years after setting it up, I moved the Unit to the Institute of Education, and there we set up a new Centre with a different name, called "The Centre for Longitudinal Studies", making it explicit that that's what it was about. And it then, of course, became a very good base for the launch of the bid for the Millennium Cohort. (pp. 71- 73)

26. Setting up a think tank and bidding for the Millenial Cohort

When these battles were going on with ESRC, one has to say, and partly with the University of Essex, about who should run these studies, we set up a thing called "The Joint Centre for Longitudinal Research", which involved the National Centre for Social Research, run by Roger Jowell at the time, who was very influential in persuading me, on one occasion, that I shouldn't let these studies go to Essex. (LAUGHS) … But we set up this joint Centre for Longitudinal Research, and out of that came the proposal, initially, for what is the means of supporting these studies. The whole idea was to have a kind of little structure and a network of people which, ultimately, became what was called "Long View": it's true to say, a think tank, really, grew out of that.

But in the meantime, it was also about the Millennium Cohort. When the government suddenly… announced at the time of the Millennium, and in Parliament, they would …[pledge] hypothecated funding to ESRC to do a birth cohort, which could record the lives of babies born at the millennium, you know, that iconic/symbolic - no other reason! But, of course, it was great. There was a 30-year gap between the '70 cohort, and that period. The '70 cohort, in 2000, was 30 years old. The ESRC then put out a kind of invitation to tender,

initially, for a mini scoping study for the Millennium Cohort Study, and initially released one-year's funding, I think, for a proposal to do it. And we, jointly – Michael Marmot and I, and the guy from City University, where it had been located - the study – we put together, we were joint applicants for the Millennium Cohort Study, and I directed it for a year before Heather Joshi took it over. and then she was my Deputy Director in, initially, in SSRU, and then in the Institute of Education, where we moved to set up the Centre for Longitudinal Studies. (pp. 72-3)

27. The 1990s: Beginning to See Social Research as Investment

I think the whole business, from the entry into the Institute, was about consolidating these studies, and building what was a whole kind of infrastructure for their development and use. And ESRC had switched dramatically, partly in its whole attitude. Because it was originally Howard Newby, from Essex, of course, who chaired what was called the Research Resources Committee, or … Resources Board. And ESRC then through that Board, began to see things [more] like Essex [did]. Originally, BHPS was the first that they really took on, and that was their pride and joy, in a sense. But then the cohort studies benefited from that by also becoming now seen as research resources. And the language of investment, and all that started beginning. They refer to [the cohorts] as "ESRC investments", and they're going to stay with them because they are recognising, in effect, the huge returns that come from them in academic and policy terms. So we then were now beginning to get money, much more substantially, and there was "Research Centre Status" from ESRC, or "Resource Centre Status". But Heather Joshi was particularly effective in some of this in working with me, and she succeeded me, in fact, as the Director of CLS when I retired. 2003 was my official retirement…

So teams of people began to be in place. We'd always had a very strong group who would trace the studies continually. That had been established in City University, on quite a large scale, and when a survey was going to be done, the idea would be to have six or eight people doing nothing else but ringing people up and trying to track down cohort members who they'd lost touch with… All of that continued in the Institute, together with all the data, which was all hard copy data, tons and tons and tons of questionnaires, all deposited in - it was locked, like a dungeon in City, and it really went to a similar dungeon in the Institute of

Ed.. So all of this work was, was trying to prove, I suppose, the theory that all of this would suddenly come good, and more and more value would be seen in these studies was correct.

And it turned out to be. One of the turning points, in a way, was economists began to get interested in it. No, I mean, initially, I don't think economists ever imagined using these sorts of data sets, but when they did, one or two very energetic and inspired young economists like Leon Feinstein, for example, who came to work with us. They became great promoters of these studies, and economists tend to be listened to more than most other social scientists by government, so that government side was working well, as well as the ESRC side. And, of course, the ESRC, itself, was continuing developing its own strategic reviews of how to bring the whole thing together in funding terms. It had given up the idea, finally, of merging everything into one single place, but it wanted to be on board with the MRC in the funding of these studies, but also governments. So the three key stakeholders would be ESRC, MRC, and government, and that's exactly how the Millennium Cohort was funded**…** (pp. 75-76)

ESRC then, through Peter Elias, who was the Tsar of Longitudinal Studies (LAUGHS)…… he then appointed us [The Centre for Longitudinal Studies] to do what was a strategic review of cohort and longitudinal studies, and that became the policy document on which the expansion of the BHPS was achieved, and the decision to launch new sweeps of the cohort studies, and to preserve the commitment to the infrastructure to maintain these studies, and also to try and fill the gap, the missing cohort, by building out of that the longitudinal study of young people.

So it had a number of objectives – long view. And all of these came together. Then it held Annual Conferences. And it then got the job of actually ... Oh, the other thing it did, of course, of most biggest importance, was decide to argue the case for a new birth cohort study, to continue the survey, the series, that the Millennium Cohort Study had now kicked off. (pp. 79-80)

28. Creating International Connections and Institutions

But I should say, before we get on to these international things, the institutionalisation of life course study, this isn't really, I suppose, my contribution to social science or sociology, except in the sense of, as I say, infrastructure…

Well, these long view meetings, we planned to invite - now, one or two of them were very much consultative for the wider - to bring in expertise, particularly of the USA and other

places that could be valuable in relation to developing the scientific case for the new birth cohort study, for example. So we used some money to bring in Americans and others to these projects, and that began to make us realise the whole value of - not exactly harmonisation, but communication with other studies, and seeing this as a world-wide enterprise that needed certain elements of co-ordination, or shared interest, opportunities to debate and meet, present data, communicate findings, and collaborate over design. But our first step in that direction, and long view decided to do this, having done about four years of various kinds of scoping activity and one-off projects of various sorts – I won't go into all the details… One of them was, for example, to help demonstrate to the Scottish Government how longitudinal data could enable them to evaluate their strategic objectives. That kind of work. So we did quite a lot of that, and ran various kinds of promotional activities and meetings.

Anyway, we finally decided, in the last period, in the light of this, these conferences, partly, and the international connections which we all, anyway, were building, to set up a journal, which was *The Journal for Longitudinal and Life Course Studies*. We went to the Nuffield Foundation who, unusually, decided to support us. And we said, "This will be quite unique. There's no other journal that will meet this need. The need is there across the world. And, therefore, we'd like to be the people who develop it, is the idea". So we got the journal established, on a three-year Nuffield Development Grant, and it started publishing in 2009, and it's been publishing ever since. I think it's in its 16th issue now … But when the Nuffield grant ran out, we were then forced, of course, to look for our own forms of funding…… Well, … within a year or so, we decided, well, the best way to do this is, is to recognise, if you like, the symbiotic relationship between a journal like the one we set up, and the learned society. And then the learned society, through the fees of its members, can both support the Society, but also generate money to support the journal. And so that's what we did. We converted what were the "Long View Conferences" into - one of them, the last item on the agenda was to establish a society, and the Society for Longitudinal Studies was born then, in 2010. … Anyway, the Society has got about three or four hundred members and it meets, annually, in different European capitals. And the international side of it was very much based on the fact that it moved all the time, it wouldn't be just UK based. … So although about 40-50 per cent of the members are, in fact, from the UK, the second largest group is American. (pp. 81-3)

[So] the other side of my work, has been so involved in this institutionalisation, making things work, and fitting into this framework of growth and development, which I think I've contributed to, but is now, I think, now, a very important established aspect of this whole terrain. (p. 90)

29. Cross-National and Intergenerational Studies

Through the development of the Journal and the Society, what I came to increasingly recognise, was the value of two developments of these studies. Cross- national comparative longitudinal studies of the kind that the BHPS and what's the expanded version of the BHPS called? "Understanding Society", yeah, which is the huge Household Panel Study. But all of these, that was a model, then, for increasingly looking for comparative opportunities for birth cohort studies. But, also, the other development was inter-generational development – following up the children of these cohort studies - which is what we also began to do. (p 83)

30. Emerging Adulthood as a Life Stage

"Emerging adulthood" is trying to make the case for a new psycho-social stage of development. The Erikssonian stage is a psycho-stage, stages that everybody has to go through, in effect, or some don't get very far, they never get out of an early one, you know! But Jeffrey Arnett made a huge splash, again in the *American Psychologist* with an article suggesting that a new psycho-social change was present in the sense that no longer did adulthood succeed youth, there was a whole period of maturity – mainly the twenties up to thirty, or even later – when young people were in this sort of intervening ... well, I would think Erikssonians would have called a "moratorium stage", where they're putting off commitments basically, they're building various kinds of identity, and they are living together. I mean, the *Friends* television programme, do you know *Friends* ?

He was claiming that this was a universal phenomenon and that you could find it everywhere, and therefore it must be a new psycho-social stage, almost built into the genes! But anyway, the long and short of it is, I wrote an article ..... which was the one about emerging adulthood. …… And in that I was very very critical of it because it seemed, to me, to deny completely the heterogeneity of societies and class and all the rest of it, which certainly in this country, is still quite a dominant structural feature, and therefore it was quite ridiculous to wash all this out in a single set of stages that every individual in a society was supposed to go through. (pp. 86-87)

31. Linked Lives and Cohorts

This is a counter to the notion that agency is a human [that] it's very much individual functioning aspect of personality, you might say. And the idea of linked lives, which comes from Elder, is enormously important as a complement to that, that we move in cohorts. Although we interview individuals and originally pick them up in that way, they are very much part of this kind of collection of individuals to whom they relate. And I think what I was trying to say is that needs recognising by going more, you might say, in the Household Panel Study direction of seeing more about families, collecting information from siblings, and also bringing in these wider social contexts of employment, schools - obviously involving teachers more in collecting. (pp. 87-88)

32. Mixed Methods

I'd been very influenced by Becker, Howard Becker's book on medical students. I've always drawn on quite a lot of other kinds of research [besides] quantitative, and increasingly over my career I've moved more and more away from seeing any distinction really, in what people are doing – they're just using different approaches. (p. 24)

You can't answer a lot of the questions satisfactorily, that you're interested in, particularly the processes in which individuals actually change - their lives change - except in the most simplistic way quantitatively, and the richness of individual experience, the exercise of agency in making choice in actually shaping the environment as well as being shaped by it, all of that is where the door opens to much more qualitatively oriented inquiry. That's where I see the complementarity lying. To me, it's never been a matter of a schism, one paradigm versus another, though we used to argue ourselves to bits over that in the OU! (LAUGHS) It's a matter, then, of seeing, well, what are the questions you're trying to answer, and what are the methods that can answer them. (pp. 47-8)

The other aspect was, I think, what amounts to ethnographic extensions, but through use of qualitative methods to actually identify sub-groups or individuals who would be worthy of investigation that way, to back more the processes in their lives, which a single interview with them, in a quantitative survey, is not going to reveal very much. You can get at general statistical tendencies, identify some sorts of mechanism and process that's going on, but to really understand it fully and why, how individual lives operate, how they're made up, you

need this other method. Complementary methodology, is how I'd see it. I don't see them in conflict, I see them as complementary. (p. 88)

33. Retirement

Well, I saw retirement, because it's a very artificial age, …… This was a new opportunity for a new career, and I was very positive about retirement, not because it was retiring from work, but I was retiring from a particular job into another. Well, it was even a paid job after a while, and that was the whole business of Long View. So I continue to take that attitude, that I still value the stimulus of work, intellectual activity, and organisational things, and I would be reluctant to lose those. I'd feel there was a void. I wouldn't fill it with doing pottery or something, if I gave it up. I'd like to think I would, but I'm being honest with myself. I need things like deadlines and pressures! (p. 95)